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Engineering

Civil and Environmental Engineering

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RE: Vivek Mishra's application for EB-2 NIW

To Whom It May Concern:

My name is Maxim A. Dulebenets, and I am an Associate Professor and Graduate Program Director in the Department of Civil and Environmental Engineering at Florida A&M University - Florida State University College of Engineering, where I lead and conduct interdisciplinary research in transportation systems, logistics, operations research, and optimization. The FAMU-FSU College of Engineering is a joint college created by the Florida Legislature in 1982 to serve both Florida A&M University (a leading HBCU) and Florida State University, a major research university, and it is the only shared engineering college of its kind in the United States.¹

I direct federally and state-funded research projects, teach undergraduate and graduate courses, and mentor students and early-career researchers. I also serve as a reviewer and editorial board member for several scientific journals and actively contribute to multiple committees of the Transportation Research Board. I have worked in the fields of Transportation Engineering, Operations Research, Freight Logistics, Simulation Modeling, and Optimization Algorithms for approximately seventeen years, since 2006.

With this background, I believe I'm well-positioned to discuss Vivek's work. I first became familiar with him in early 2021 through his published research. Although I have not collaborated with him directly, I have cited his Caltrans- and CSULB-funded studies in my own research on Florida's transportation systems and have closely followed his contributions to intelligent transportation systems, AI-assisted mobility, and crowdsourcing strategies for public transit. His work has shaped aspects of our freight network modeling and equity-focused analyses in Florida, particularly in how we evaluate accessibility and performance under different policy constraints.

In my professional opinion, Vivek's most significant contributions lie in his ability to integrate civil engineering with advanced technologies such as artificial intelligence, automation, and blockchain to address complex transportation problems. His research on optimizing transportation access for

¹ <https://registrar.fsu.edu/bulletin/undergraduate-colleges/engineering>
<https://eng.famu.fsu.edu/about>

underserved populations and automating freight mobility analysis demonstrates a rare combination of methodological rigor and practical relevance. These contributions have influenced public-sector research and infrastructure strategy, providing tools and frameworks that public agencies can use to plan better, simulate, and evaluate transportation investments, including under equity and social distancing constraints. The fact that his work has been funded by prominent public agencies and cited in state-level research efforts beyond California underscores its broader national impact. Specifically, I am intimately familiar with Vivek's research paper titled "**Evaluating Financing Mechanisms and Economic Benefits to Fund Grade Separation Projects**" (2021), as I explicitly cited this work in my own study, "Towards improving sustainability of rail transport by reducing traffic delays at level crossings: A case study for the State of Florida". I am aware that this foundational research was supported by prestigious funding from the U.S. Department of Transportation (USDOT) through the **Mineta Transportation Institute (MTI)** and the **California State University Transportation Consortium (CSUTC)**. This direct citation and the funding acknowledgments within his published work confirm my knowledge of his significant contributions to federally supported transportation infrastructure research.

Based on the documented impact of his Caltrans and CSULB-funded projects, specifically the use of multiobjective optimization for High-Speed Rail station development and his AI-driven cost-benefit analysis for grade separation, it is clear that Vivek has played a critical role in shaping research innovations for the California Department of Transportation and related programs. His participation goes well beyond technical execution, encompassing intellectual leadership in the design, implementation, and interpretation of publicly funded research.

Additionally, he has served in multiple roles, judging the work of others, including reviewing technical papers for premier machine learning conferences such as NeurIPS (Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems) and ICLR (International Conference on Learning Representations), which are highly selective and globally recognized venues in artificial intelligence and deep learning².

He has also evaluated applications for IEEE Senior Member elevation. This process requires assessing candidates' technical achievements and professional standing and has acted as a mentor and judge in various university-level hackathons and innovation competitions involving postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, and industry professionals. Collectively, these activities reflect the high degree of trust that the broader scientific and engineering community places in his judgment and expertise.

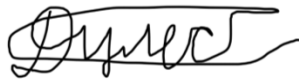
In light of U.S. immigration regulations that require evidence that a beneficiary is among the small percentage who have risen to the very top of their field and enjoy sustained national or international acclaim, I consider Vivek clearly among the top emerging contributors at the intersection of artificial intelligence and transportation planning. His research has been supported by competitive public funding such as that from the U.S. Department of Transportation and the California State University Transportation Consortium (CSUTC) under the SB-1 initiative, to reiterate, I am specifically aware that his research on grade separation and financing mechanisms was made possible through competitive grants from the Mineta Transportation Institute (MTI), a USDOT-designated University Transportation Center, and the State of California's Senate Bill 1 (SB-1) program. These are prominent funding sources in our

² https://scholar.google.es/citations?view_op=top_venues&hl=en&vq=eng_artificialintelligence

field that support high-impact research with direct implications for public policy and infrastructure development, further validating the caliber of Vivek's work cited by independent scholars (including in the fields of freight logistics and real estate), and used to inform similar lines of inquiry in multiple U.S. states (including Florida) and internationally (in countries like Italy and Iran).

Vivek brings an interdisciplinary depth, combining AI, programming, and infrastructure modeling, that is both rare and increasingly essential in modern transportation research. Transportation as a discipline is becoming more data-driven and computational, and he has anticipated this shift by developing tools that align with academic objectives while remaining deployable for real-world policy evaluation. In my view, his profile and body of work place him in a category that is genuinely difficult to replicate in the current U.S. talent market.

Sincerely,



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